



Participant Information Sheet

Study name: The power of householders in Ireland to drive sustainable food systems

Who we are

My name is Nicole Olweean and I am a PhD student at the University of Galway. My overall research explores the ways that householders—people in general—think about and act on sustainability when it comes to food, how people might be willing to change what they do to support food sustainability, and what could help support these changes. I also want to determine how people’s nutrition, as well as Ireland’s greenhouse gas emissions and other environmental impacts, would be affected if these changes were adopted. I am supervised by Dr Anne Mullen, who is a Registered Public Health Nutritionist and Lecturer in Nutrition Security at University of Galway.

What is the purpose of this study?

The choices we make in how we plan, buy, process, prepare, consume, store, and dispose of food—what we call “food practices”—can affect our health and the environment’s health. These food practices are influenced by many different factors, including things like our distance from the nearest shop, our preferences, and how much time we’re able to devote to food practices, as well as rising food prices, cost of living, circumstances of food poverty (experienced by nearly 1 in 10 people in Ireland), and social pressures to eat in certain ways. We believe that each person’s everyday food practices and the circumstances and decisions behind them hold great power to change the impact global food systems have on human and planetary health.

In this study, we want to capture the reality of people’s lived experiences with food, including understanding how, why, where, and when you make the daily choices you make around food, and whether/how you feel these choices affect your health and the environment. We also want to know if you think any of your practices could change to be healthier or more sustainable, and what you think could help support these changes.

Invitation

We invite households in Galway City/County containing at least one adult to participate in this research project. To help you make an informed choice about whether you would like to participate, we’ve provided the following information about our study and what your participation will involve. Please read this information carefully and discuss it all members of your household. You may also wish to discuss it with others or with the researchers. If you find anything unclear or would like more information, please don’t hesitate to contact us.

What do we mean by “household”?



For the purpose of this study, we define a household as a single person or group of people who usually live in the same home. Household members do not need to be related by blood or marriage to be considered a household.

Here are some examples we would consider a household:

- ✓ One person living alone
- ✓ Romantic partners sharing a home
- ✓ Unrelated housemates who share living accommodation, whether they buy and eat shared food or buy and eat their food separately.
- ✓ A family with one or more guardians and one or more children

Here are some other situations to consider:

- ✗ A family member who permanently lives and works away from home is not considered a member of the household, even if they visit on holidays.
- ✗ Children away for higher education (such as college students living away) are not considered a member of the household unless they are present in the house for the entire duration of the study.

Eligibility

To take part in this study, your household must be within Galway City or County and everyone aged 18 or older in your household must agree to take part in the study. You must have English language proficiency and have access to the internet through a mobile device or computer. We will utilize the WhatsApp platform for data collection, so you must be willing to adopt and use that platform for exchanging information with the research team.

What would taking part involve?

If you participate in the study, you and members of your household aged 18 and over will complete several surveys, collect and send data through WhatsApp over a 3-day period on your household's food practice, and take part in an in-person household interview.

Surveys

1. Nutrition – we will measure weight and height for all household members in order to calculate nutrition requirements. We will also measure body composition for all mobile adults in the household. We will ask about special diets related to health, and about typical and special dietary behaviours in the household.
2. Food Frequency Questionnaire (FFQ) – We will gather some information on what is usually eaten by household members.
3. Behavioural characteristics around environmental activities – We'll ask some questions about householder attitudes and the intentions householders have regarding sustainability.



4. Household energy survey – we will ask a few questions about how energy gets used in your household.
5. Home Food Inventory – we will do a brief inventory of the food in your home at the time of the study.

Food practice diary

Household members aged 18 and over will be asked to complete a food practice diary for 3 consecutive days, with at least one of the days falling on a weekend and including a day where the bulk of food shopping is done (if your household has a particular day for a weekly shop). In this diary, you will record all your interactions with food, including practices like gathering knowledge about food, planning, shopping, transporting, cooking, storing, and disposing of food waste. You will be asked to record information in the diary using a printed booklet and WhatsApp, and recording information will include some writing, voice notes, photos, and videos. **This diary is expected to take between 60 and 75 minutes of your time per day for three days.** If you choose to take part in this study, you will be trained by the researchers in how to complete the diary.

Interviews

Interviews will be held within one month after your food diary is completed and will take between 30 and 60 minutes. In advance of the interview, we will email your household a short report on your food practice in terms of providing your nutritional needs, healthy eating, and environmental impacts. The interview will be an informal conversation about your current food practices and any tools or supports that could support healthy and sustainable future food practices. It will be held in your own home or, at your request, in an agreed-upon public location, such as the University of Galway. The interview will be led by either Nicole Olweean (PhD student), Rose Wafer (MSc student), or Dr Anne Mullen, and will be audio-recorded so that it can be transcribed in full after the session. Before beginning, your facilitator will explain how the interview will work and answer any questions you have. During both the food diary period and the interview, you may choose not to answer any question you do not wish to answer.

Science-policy-society event

The researchers may contact you to attend and participate in a science-policy-society event to be held at the end of this study. Researchers may invite you to display your project artifacts (i.e. food practice photos) at this event, but attendance and participation will be completely optional and the decision to take part will be entirely yours.

What will happen if I do not want to carry on with the study?

Your participation is voluntary. You are free to withdraw your participation and your data any time without giving any reason until the study data undergoes analysis so it can be submitted for publication in a scientific journal.



You may also have concerns about how your information is handled. More on this can be found in the next section.

Confidentiality and data protection

Personal data will be collected during this study, including your name, gender, age, education, income band, ethnicity, and contact details (email address). This information is collected because we believe that, in Ireland, these are related to food practices. We will also collect information on your nutrition status: your body composition, your diet, and the healthfulness of your diet in relation to your requirements. This information is collected because it allows us to study food practices in terms of human health.

Your name and contact details will be linked to a unique ID and will be stored on a password protected file on a password protected computer in the University of Galway. This information will not be shared and will be deleted permanently after 7 years. By using a unique ID, your identity is never linked to the study data, and you cannot be identified from it. However, if you wish to withdraw your data from the study, you may withdraw at any point during the study or at a later stage, up until the data undergoes final analysis for submission to a scientific journal. University of Galway is the sponsor for this study, based in Galway, Ireland. We will act as the data controller and will be responsible for using and storing your information properly. We will store and process personal data in line with the purposes outlined in the study and in line with GDPR.

Here are some key points about how your information will be handled:

1. **Confidentiality:** All information submitted by you for this study will be treated as strictly confidential and kept securely. It will not be possible to identify you in any reporting or publications that come from the study.
2. **Personally identifiable information (PII):** All information submitted by you will be anonymized, meaning any PII (your name, etc.) that could be used to personally connect you with your responses will not be attached to your responses during data analysis or in results. Instead, a unique identifier code linking your PII with the study data will be used and your PII will be stored separately. We will continue to store your PII so that we know which information is yours in case you wish to withdraw it from the study at any point. To safeguard your rights, we will use the minimum PII possible.
3. **Data storage:** Your PII will be stored in a password-protected file on a password-protected computer that will be kept in a locked office at the University of Galway. All data you provide (anonymized so that it cannot be connected to you) will be kept in a password-protected file on the University of Galway's cloud server. Anonymized transcripts from the interview will be verified for accuracy by the head researcher, and the audio files will be permanently deleted immediately after verification.

Open data principles are an important part of research that allow citizens, other researchers, and research reviewers to have access to raw data from research studies. This supports transparency in research and allows raw data to be used by other researchers to further knowledge. In keeping with these principles, we intend to make our research data available in an online data repository,



where it will be available indefinitely. In this repository, responses from the questionnaire will be included and an analysis of interview transcripts will be included—full interview transcripts will not be included. **Your PII will not be included in the data stored in this repository and you will not be identifiable through this data.**

University of Galway will securely store identifiable information about you for 7 years after the research project has ended, and then it will be deleted. Likewise, all anonymized questionnaire responses and focus group transcripts will be deleted from the University of Galway server after 7 years.

Confidentiality of the data provided cannot be absolutely guaranteed by the researchers and can only be protected within the limitations of the law. To learn more about data protection policies at the University of Galway, visit: <https://www.universityofgalway.ie/data-protection/>

If you have questions or concerns regarding your data protection, please feel free to contact the university's Data Protection Officer using the information below:

The Data Protection Officer,
University of Galway, Room A129,
The Quadrangle, University of Galway,
University Road, Galway
Email: dataprotection@universityofgalway.ie

What are the possible benefits of taking part?

All participants will receive a report on household diet and food practice overview, detailing the nutritional, economic, and environmental impacts of your current food practices as well as how these could change based on diet and practice changes. Participating in this study could also give you the opportunity to observe and learn more about your own food practices, perhaps noticing patterns or habits. We hope all participants will be happy to know they have contributed to new knowledge that will support shifts to healthier and more sustainable food systems. We aim to recruit 30 households to the study. All households that complete the study will receive healthy eating advice based on advice for the population in Ireland from the Department of Health. All households that complete the study will also be entered into a random draw for one of six €50 shopping vouchers.

What are the possible disadvantages or risks of taking part?

You might feel that your participation could be a burden on your time or create a sense of pressure, which could lead to stress. Please carefully read the time estimates for participation so you can decide if the commitment is feasible for you at this time.

You might also feel uncomfortable sharing information about your food practices with researchers and other participants. We would like to reassure you that there are no such things as perfect diets or food practices. We also understand that diets and food practices are influenced by more than just our knowledge and desires; among other things, they're also influenced by the current



high cost of living and rising food prices, as well as circumstances of food poverty that nearly 1 in 10 people in Ireland experience. Our purpose is to take a realistic snapshot of people's lived experiences with food, and they will not be held to or judged against any standard or ideal.

We note that not all food practices within a household may be agreed upon by all members of the household, and that the practices and values around food between household members may at times be in conflict. You might feel uncomfortable surfacing these conflicts or sharing them with researchers. We would like to reassure you that there is no expectation of cohesive food practice among household members and that we consider any disagreements that arise around food practice to be part of a realistic snapshot of lived experiences with food. Also, you are under no obligation to share about disagreements around food practice.

It is possible that some participants may consider their relationship with food and/or eating to be complicated. In such cases, in-depth discussion of food practices could be upsetting or could trigger thoughts or behaviors the participant wishes to avoid. We urge participants to consider this before consenting. Community groups such as BodyWhys Ireland are available for additional support.

It is also possible that conversations about environmental sustainability and its related issues (such as climate change) could trigger anxiety in some participants. Community groups such as Transition Galway/Trasdul na Gaillimhe, Headford Environment group, Friends of the Earth, and Healthy Galway City are available for additional support and as outlets for environmental/climate action.

Who is funding this study?

The funder for this study is the College of Science and Engineering at University of Galway.

Who should I contact for more information?

This study was reviewed and approved by the Research Ethics Committee at University of Galway. It has also been reviewed internally by each of the research team members at University of Galway.

If you have any questions or require more information about this study, please use the following contact details:

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What if I have further questions, or if something goes wrong?

If you would like to speak in confidence with someone about this study, if this study has harmed you in any way, or if you wish to make a complaint about the conduct of this study, please use the following contact details:

Chairperson of Research Ethics Committee
c/o The Research Office

University of Galway

Email: ethics@universityofgalway.ie

Tel: +353 91 495312

Fax: +353 91 494591

Thank you for reading this information sheet and for considering taking part in this research.